

The Sūtra of Maitreya

Maitrīsūtra · Toh 35 · Derge Kangyur

བཅུས་པའི་མདོ།

The Sūtra of Maitreya, known in Sanskrit as the Maitrīsūtra and in Tibetan as Byams pa'i mdo, is a canonical Buddhist sūtra concerning the future buddha Maitreya, the successor to the present buddha Śākyamuni. In the text, the venerable Śāriputra addresses the Blessed One at the Nyagrodha pleasure grove beside the Rohiṇī river, asking him to describe the qualities and nature of the coming buddha, and the Blessed One responds by extolling Maitreya's immeasurable merit and boundless renown. It is Toh 35 in the Kangyur, belonging to the general class of sūtra literature, and was translated into Tibetan by Zangpo at the great temple of Palthaling.

Translated and edited at the great temple Palthaling, the seat of those who speak two languages, by Zangpo. May it be like the sun and moon above the earth.

In Sanskrit: Maitrīsūtra. In Tibetan: The Sūtra of Maitreya.

With reverence I bow to the noble Three Jewels.

At one time the Teacher was dwelling at the Śākyan compound, at the Nyagrodha pleasure grove, on the banks of the Rohiṇī river. Then the venerable Śāriputra asked the Blessed One concerning that Victor of the future:

I wish with utmost care to hear
what kind of buddha your successor,
steadfast in mind, shall come to be,
revealed in full before my eyes.

Hearing the elder's question, the Blessed One spoke these words:

His heaps of merit are beyond all measure;
his great renown is unconquerable.
To speak of all his qualities is not possible.
Having summarized, let it be well set forth,
and just one portion shall be taught.

Śāriputra, listen to my words. This is the Fortunate Aeon. In the course of ten million years of birth, the one bearing the very name Maitreya shall be a

buddha, the most excellent of those who walk on two feet.

Just as after my passing five periods will arise in sequence: the period up to the fruits, the period up to accomplishment, the period up to scripture, the period of signs only, and the period up to the bodily relics.

The period up to the fruits is the time during which, within one thousand years after the buddha has passed fully into nirvāṇa, it is possible to generate realization. This passes and moves on. During it there are non-returners, once-returners, and stream-enterers. As long as these are present, one should not say that the period up to the fruits is absent. What remains is the stream-enterers; when they have passed, the period up to the fruits is said to have waned. This is what is called the waning of the period up to the fruits.

What is called the waning of the period up to accomplishment is this: when it is no longer possible to train in the fruits of the path of calm abiding and special insight, yet it remains possible to guard the four root defeats. As time passes on, one merely guards the four root defeats. As long as those who guard the four root defeats are present, even if among a thousand monks only about a hundred remain, one should not say that the period up to accomplishment has waned. But when among a hundred there remains only a single monk and that monk either breaks his vow or dies, then the period up to accomplishment is said to have waned. This is what is called the waning of the period up to accomplishment.

What is called the waning of the period up to scripture is this: when the meaning of the three scriptural collections of the Buddha's word is no longer understood and only the words are recited, yet as long as the texts themselves still exist, the period up to scripture is said to be complete. As time passes on in the age of strife, kings will engage in Dharma-less conduct. Ministers and others will likewise engage in Dharma-less conduct. Then the districts and regions will follow in the same way. On account of their Dharma-less conduct, the gods will not send down good rain, the crops will not ripen well, and because the crops do not ripen, it will not be possible to give food to the community of monks. Because the monks cannot find food, they will not be able to support pupils and students. As time passes on, the period up to scripture declines.

First the great exposition will deteriorate. When it has waned, the verse-collections of Yamaka, along with the books on foundation, person, designation, relics, analysis, and the compendium of Dharma, will fall into

decline. When the Abhidharma scriptural collection has waned, the Sūtra scriptural collection will wane. Then the later collection of the Aṅga will wane. When the later Aṅga collection has waned, the collection of the Saṃyukta will wane. Then the middle-length collection and the long collection will wane.

When the long collection has waned, the Jātakas together with the Vinaya will remain. Even in the Vinaya scriptural collection, only those possessed of a sense of shame will maintain it. As time continues to pass, even maintaining the Jātakas alone will no longer be possible. First, all the Jātakas of liberation will fall into decline. Last, the Jātakas without verse will fall into decline. When the Jātakas have waned, only the Vinaya scriptural collection alone will be maintained. As time continues to pass, if any person causes even a single verse of the Buddha's scriptures to spread, the period up to scripture will not yet have declined. At such a time when a king has faith in the Dharma, a single golden basket is placed upon the back of a great elephant, a thousand loads of treasure are placed within it, and it is proclaimed three times in the midst of the city with the sound of music, announcing that whoever knows a single verse spoken by the Buddha may take those thousand loads of treasure. When none is able to claim it, those thousand loads of treasure are deposited in the royal treasury. That time will be the time when the period up to scripture has declined. This is called the time when the period up to scripture has declined.

As time continues to pass, there will be those who hold a monastic robe and those who hold an alms bowl, resembling wandering ascetics like the naked śramaṇas, carrying a vessel of broken shards and a begging vessel, going about with something hanging from the tips of their fingers, and going along carrying things in a net. As time continues to pass, people will think: what need have I of a saffron robe? They will drape a mere scrap of cloth that has been made somewhat into Dharma-form over their hand, or neck, or ears, or cover their hair with it. Then, taking wives and engaging in farming, trade, and the like, they will go about pursuing their livelihood. At that time patrons will give offerings, donating everything for the sake of the Saṅgha. At that time I have declared that the fruit of offerings made to the Saṅgha is immeasurable, Ānanda. As time continues to pass, people will think: why should I, for my own sake, put on a piece of saffron cloth and throw it into a monastery or forest? At that time the period up to the mere holding of signs will have declined. This is called the time when the period up to the mere holding of signs has declined.

Then, in this fifth period of a thousand years of the teaching of the perfectly and fully awakened buddha, gain, honor, and the like will be scarce. The relics will go to places where they receive gain and veneration. As time continues to pass, not having received veneration and respect in any land, at the final time of the teaching, coming from all the lands of the nāgas, the worlds of the gods, and all the abodes of the world of Brahmā, all the relics will be gathered together at the very heart of awakening, the seat of enlightenment alone. Having become the buddha's body, they will display to others what resembles the lord of death performing many miraculous feats. At that place there will not even be a name for sentient beings who have become human. All assembled within the entire surrounding sphere of the divine worlds of ten thousand realms, they will weep: "Today the one with the ten powers passes completely into nirvāṇa. From this day forward, all becomes darkness." The element of fire will arise in all the relics and will burn away whatever remains of that body without remainder. This is called the time when the period of the relics declines.

Then, when in this fifth period of a thousand years the teaching has declined, non-virtue will increase greatly among worldly beings. This is the meaning of what is said. People will become without shame and without conscience, and will lose all perception of distinction regarding their mothers, daughters, sisters, and the like. They will be without shame, like pigs and jackals and the like. Thereafter, applying themselves to non-virtue, their lifespan will diminish until it reaches ten years. Boys of five years will take girls of five years as wives.

Within those same five years, sons and daughters and grandsons and granddaughters will also be born. During that time, before the intermediate kalpa of weapons arrives, there will be three intermediate kalpas of calamity: the intermediate kalpa of famine, the intermediate kalpa of disease, and the intermediate kalpa of weapons. Of these, when craving arises excessively in the sentient beings of the world, there will be an intermediate kalpa of famine. When delusion becomes exceedingly great, there will be an intermediate kalpa of disease. When that which has become corrupt reaches its time, there will be an intermediate kalpa of weapons. The intermediate kalpa of famine devastates sentient beings and causes them to be reborn as hungry ghosts. The intermediate kalpa of disease devastates sentient beings and causes them to be reborn as animals. The intermediate kalpa of weapons devastates sentient beings and causes them to be reborn in the hells.

At the time of the intermediate kalpa of weapons, people will come to perceive one another as wild game, and seizing weapons with one edge, with two edges, and blades sharp as razors, they will slaughter one another. Whoever among them is wise, hearing of the destruction taking place, will take seven days' worth of food and hide themselves away in mountain gorges and the like. The remaining sentient beings who did not hide will strike and kill one another. Every inch of the earth will become flesh and blood.

At that time great clouds will gather and send down rain. Following the rain sent by the gods, rain of sweet fragrance will fall and fall. In that time all places will become pleasing. All places will be purified, and then rain bearing husked grain will fall and fall. After the rain bearing husked grain has fallen, rain of husked grain no more will fall and fall. After that, rain of clothing and ornaments will fall and fall. At the end, rain of all seven precious substances, each as large in measure as a knee-joint, will fall and fall.

Concerning this, the Blessed One declared in verse:

Rain of sweet fragrance falls,
then rain of grain with husk and grain without,
then rain of clothing and adornments —
thus like a garden beautiful.
All seven precious substances without remainder
rain down upon that very place.
Having filled every place completely,
at that time, like a garden beautiful.

When those calamities have passed, those who had hidden emerge. Having emerged, they embrace one another, weep, and recalling wholesome qualities such as the five precepts of moral discipline, they take them up completely and begin to practice them. Then the children, sons and daughters, born from those people whose lifespan was ten years will see their lifespans increase to twenty years. Thereafter, as the Dharma increases greatly among people, the lifespan will grow in due sequence until it becomes immeasurable years. At that time sentient beings will no longer see aging and death. And so other sentient beings too will become heedful, thinking nothing of what is called the suffering of the hells. Then those immeasurable years will once again begin to diminish. Diminishing as before, the lifespan will reach eighty thousand years. At that time, all of Jambudvīpa will be filled with women endowed with the fortune of divine maidens, and men as well. Divine rain will fall for a

half-month, for ten days, for five days, and for a half-day, causing the essence of the earth to increase. At that time all the ground will be level, without thorns or rough timber, and cities will have gates on all four sides, and in the center of each city a wish-fulfilling tree will grow.

Concerning this it is said:

The cities of that age
will have varied markets, each distinct,
with fine parks and ponds in full bloom,
with joy and plentiful dwelling,
with great waters free of impurity,
utterly cold and bearing sweet fragrance,
clear, even, and satisfying,
their sediment settled perfectly below,
filled with lotuses and blue water-lilies,
without churning waves or turbidity,
ringed by seven rows of palm trees
and covered over with precious things by nature,
furnished with seven iron mountain ranges,
with all cities interconnected —
and the palace of Kuśa the King
at that time will be adorned with pinnacles.

At the four gates of each city
wish-fulfilling trees will grow,
shining forth in radiant light
of blue, of gold, of red, and white.
Divine garments will grow there,
and by divine grace the ornaments
and all manner of goods for enjoyment
will hang down overhead from those trees.

Then in the center of each city
there will be buildings on four sides,
and what is brought forth by the karma of merit
will appear from the wish-fulfilling tree:
fine wool cloth and excellent cotton,
cloth of udumbara fiber —
all these, produced by the karma of merit,

will appear from the wish-fulfilling tree.

Hand drums of mṛdaṅga,
muraja and ālambha drums —
all these, arisen from the karma of merit,
will appear from the wish-fulfilling tree.

Ornaments for the shoulder, with their finery,
armlets and necklaces,
neck ornaments of precious nature —
all these, arisen from the karma of merit,
will appear from the wish-fulfilling tree.

Ornaments for the forehead and the face,
jeweled pendants adorning the body —
all these, arisen from the karma of merit,
will appear from the wish-fulfilling tree.

And furthermore, adorned with every kind
of ornament in all their variety,
all these, accomplished by the karma of merit,
will appear from the wish-fulfilling tree.

Unsown, unplanted, self-arisen,
born of the karma of merit,
unhusked, without bran, without impurity,
the rice, bearing a sweet and fragrant scent —
when that rice is cooked for use,
people shall enjoy it fully.
That rice will be inexhaustible,
and a hundred thousand measures will come forth.
The rice shoots will spring up
and spread everywhere throughout the land,
and from each single stalk of rice
one after another a new shoot will arise.
The fragrance of that rice will be enjoyed
by people in every direction.

A measure of two thousand cart-loads,
of about one hundred cart-loads,
of thirty-nine cart-loads,

and of sixteen great measures —
then again two kubyas —
such is the rice that will come forth.
From a single seed there will grow
what the merit-karma of beings produces.

Whoever abides bearing a crown —
the Conch-King, sovereign of men —
at that time it will be thus for him:
he shall bear the adornment of virtuous qualities,
all his wishes completely fulfilled.
With a beautiful face and adorned with earrings,
his body anointed with haricandana sandalwood,
clothed in the finest Kāśī silk,
his wealth vast and abundant,
he shall be awakened by the tinkling of vīṇā strings,
ever exceedingly joyful,
his body and mind at ease —
and Jambudvīpa will extend ten thousand leagues.

Free of thorns and free of rough timber,
level, soft, and fragrant with green pasture,
only three sicknesses will arise:
desire, and hunger, and old age.

A woman five hundred years of age
will be taken as a bride by old and young alike,
and both shall always be in happiness
and live without quarrel.

Fruits and harvests in full abundance,
vines and creepers in groves of trees —
the grass will grow to four finger-widths,
soft as the finest wool.

Not too cold, not too warm,
the rain falling evenly,
the wind exceedingly gentle,
the seasons arriving in due measure,
the rivers no shallower than a palm tree's height,

each region and its portion of land —
the stones of that earth will be small,
no larger than a black sesame or a white sesame seed,
filled entirely with what resembles pearls.
The ornamental gardens will be beautiful,
joyful, and delightful to behold.
Filled with many towns and villages,
each set close beside the next,
they will be like a dense grove of reeds standing in the light.

only as far as a bird can fly in one breath.
Virtuous, prosperous, and possessed of miraculous power,
living in accord with natural order, free from harm,
ever playful and joyful,
wholly satisfied in bliss,
encircled by the bliss of the lunar mansions,
glad, content, and supremely delighted.
They eat and drink abundantly,
meat and ale plentiful as water.
The palace of the gods like a willow grove,
the royal palace, a magnificent mansion,
is like the sound of a lute, pleasing to the senses.
Jambudvīpa too shall become like this.

At that time, the bodhisattva Maitreya (Loving-kindness), having perfected the perfection of generosity over sixteen immeasurable eons and one hundred thousand eons, and having fully completed the thirty perfections while giving away his remaining births as great gifts of body that liberate all beings, and having completely fulfilled all the perfections, will pass from that life and take a perfect rebirth in the Joyful Heaven, Tuṣita. Then it will be proclaimed that the buddha will come. The gods of the ten-thousand world-systems will swear an oath, declaring that the buddha will come. He will gaze in all five directions, then, surrounded by the assembly and retinue of the gods of Tuṣita, he will depart from Tuṣita. He will enter the womb of Brahmāvatī, a brahmin woman of the lineage of Śaṅkhapāla the chief chanter, foremost among brahmins, in the palace of the king named Ketu, and ten thousand world-systems will tremble. After ten months have passed, he will emerge from the womb of his mother, who dwells in a place frequented by fallen sages and wandering deer,

and he will gradually come to full awareness. By the power of his own merit, he will press the earth down and rise upward, and in four magnificent palaces of the seven precious substances, like a god unto himself, he will take company with many women like goddesses, including the goddess Candramukhī, Lady of the Moon-face. For a full thousand years he will enjoy himself as a god. Then one day, upon seeing the form of one who has gone forth into renunciation, he will become like the lion king who takes no delight in a golden cage, feeling profound disenchantment with all the prosperity and the magnificent jewel-palaces, perfect and without remainder, and the wish for true renunciation will arise in him.

All the gods of the ten-thousand world-systems will take divine flowers and the like in their hands, gathering in this single world-system, and the great beings, headed by Śaṅkha-pāla the king of conch, will receive him, surrounding the magnificent palace with fragrant perfumes, garlands, and incense. The gods of the sky, taking divine flowers in hand, will all together raise the cry of "Excellent!" and this sound will resound in unison and remain even up to the Akaniṣṭha heaven. At that time the magnificent jewel-palace will spin like a potter's wheel and travel through the sky, like the moon in the sign of Pisces encircled by a garland of lunar mansions. The great queen consort of the bodhisattva and the others will pass through the sky. Those who travel with a mind to accompany this great bodhisattva will each look up into their own portion of the sky, and the great Brahmā will hold a white canopy measuring three leagues across. The divine king Śakra (Indra) will take up a conch and other instruments and blow them. Thus, surrounded by an assembly of gods and humans endowed with glory and good fortune, he will proceed to the tree of awakening, the nāga-tree of the magnificent palace.

The measure of that tree is this:

A hundred and twenty cubits to the highest branch,
the spread of the branches equal to that height,
the boughs winding and hanging down from above,
beautiful as the spread tail of a peacock.
Ever bright with blossoms at the crown,
carrying the fragrance of the gods,
its flower-clusters full and brimming,
its lovely blossoms the size of a wheel,
carried off in all directions by the wind,
spreading out for ten leagues.

The blossoms from above fall downward.

At the heart of awakening, blossoms were heaped in offering. At that time, flocks of birds of many kinds, moving through the sky, made offerings with their sweet and melodious calls. Thus he came to the foot of the nāga-tree of awakening, and there he dwelt, hanging in the sky, every part of the ground below being a place of delightful appearance.

For seven days he practiced austerities at the heart of that glorious place. The Great Brahmā took him in hand, gathered up his possessions, and led him forth into renunciation. The entire retinue, without exception, also went forth into renunciation.

Then, moreover, it is said:

Eighty-four thousand,
learned in the highest Brahmanical knowledge,
went forth together with Maitreya —
each one of them went forth into renunciation.

After his going forth, the goddess Moon-Face offered him a sweet and exceedingly delicious rice porridge. Having fully enjoyed it, at the evening session he leveled the ground at the foot of the tree of awakening, sat down cross-legged, and remained there, undefeated. He sat gazing toward the eastern quarter of the world. In due sequence, at the proper time, he directly realized the primordial wisdom of omniscience aspect by aspect.

This is what was proclaimed:

All beings of cyclic existence, without exception,
seeking that which is free of poison,
making a home free of poison —
yet birth again and again is suffering.
One will come to see that making a home
is making yet another home anew.
The destruction of all suffering
is the destruction of the poisoned home.
Abandoning the poison of the mind,
and with craving exhausted, one is liberated.

This was declared as the udāna.

After remaining forty-nine days at the foot of the tree of awakening, he set out for the place where the sages fell, in order to turn the wheel of Dharma at the request of Brahmā. As he proceeded there, wherever he lifted and set down each foot, lotus flowers sprang up. The petals were thirty cubits across, the smaller petals twenty-five cubits, the filaments twenty cubits, and the pericarp sixteen cubits. The filaments extended throughout, and the lotuses were furnished with all their pistils. The radiance of those lotuses, endowed with the ten powers, outshone the light of the sun, and day and night were no longer distinguished. At evening and at dawn, birds called out. The opening and closing of the blossoms marked the night and day. And wherever the Dharma was taught, the sound of Dharma resounded.

Therefore it was declared:

The measure of his light and rays of light
is the measure of his voice and resonance.

The measure of his splendor and magnificence
is the measure of his merit.

The measure of his wisdom
is the measure of his renown.

The measure of his complexion
is the measure of his Dharma.

Then the eighty-four thousand brahmins and the one hundred and eighty million Brahmās drank a nectar drink, and through the power of the merit of the Blessed One, rays of light in many hundreds of forms blazed forth. His form was perfect in the many hundreds of major marks, adorned with the foremost thirty-two major marks, and endowed with the eighty minor marks — a form of wondrous aspect in many hundreds of hues — and many hundreds of rays of light issued from his body. His complexion shone with rays of blue, yellow, red, and white, and with rays the color of madder. From his body arose rays of light extending to the height of a palmyra tree. At times appropriate and inappropriate, in pairs and unpaired, in aggregates and singly, rays circumambulated the body of the Blessed One three times, then extended far and near. The body of that Blessed One stood eighty-eight cubits in height. From the soles of the feet to the knees: twenty-two cubits. From the knees to the navel: twenty-two cubits.

From the navel to the collar-bone: twenty-two cubits. From the collar-bone to the crown of the head: twenty-two cubits. The span between the two

shoulders: twenty-five cubits. Each shoulder measured five cubits in length. From the tip of each ear to its base: seven cubits each. The lip of each eye: five cubits each. The span of each eyebrow: five cubits each. The width of the space between the two eyebrows: five cubits. The chin: seven cubits. The lip of each of the upper and lower lips: ten cubits each. The roundness of the tongue: five cubits. The uṣṇīṣa: five cubits. The orb of the face, which resembled a golden mirror: twenty-five cubits. The neck: five cubits. The length of each of the two arms: forty-four cubits each.

Such, then, is the boundless splendor of the peerless buddha — the magnificent display of that buddha. Dwelling among the gods of all the world-systems of ten thousand world-spheres and then among the humans who follow after them, he turned the wheel of Dharma. In the places where he taught the Dharma, a hundred billion gods and humans were released from their bonds. Those who had attained the first fruit of the Dharma and those who had not yet attained it were born in the higher realms.

Who among those possessed of supreme loving-kindness would fail to behold him? Those who would not behold him are these: those who have killed their mothers, those who have killed their fathers, those who have expelled a nun, those who have split the Saṅgha, those who have committed the five acts of immediate retribution, those who have destroyed a stūpa, those who have cut down the tree of awakening, those who have killed a bodhisattva, those who have ruined the Saṅgha's food, those of extreme miserliness, those confirmed in wrong views, those who slander noble persons, and those of the Nirgrantha sect — these would not behold him.

All of these narratives of the great birth-stories of Tārā, each adorned with a thousand verses, if spoken and heard by people in the course of a single day — or if one offers a thousand lamps, or a thousand common flowers, or a thousand blue utpala lotuses, or if one builds a stūpa, or makes an image of the buddha and makes offerings to it — then at the time of the awakening of Maitreya the buddha, one will be reborn in his presence and attain the first Dharma. As for the remaining sentient beings — those who give gifts, observe moral discipline, sweep a temple, plant a tree of awakening, build a stūpa, tend to a stūpa and a tree of awakening, lay out a garden, erect a bridge, repair a road, build a rest-house, dig a well, perform the work of the teaching, clean a Dharma center, make offerings of incense and garlands and the like, listen to the Dharma with reverence, give even a meal's worth of food to the Saṅgha, honor one's father and mother, honor the head of one's clan, give

food to those who observe the restoration ceremony, give gifts to a chance ascetic, give to a mendicant — those who offer a seat will behold the perfectly and fully awakened buddha Maitreya.

Even those who offer only a single handful of flowers, or merely a single lamp, or who rejoice in the virtuous deeds of others, or gods and humans who perform these virtuous acts — at that time, when the perfectly and fully awakened buddha Maitreya arrives, they too will behold him.

As for those who wish to behold the perfectly and fully awakened buddha Maitreya: if they practice giving, observe moral discipline, perform the acts of the restoration ceremony, cultivate meditation, and are heedful in virtuous action, they will without doubt behold him.

Those who live the holy life of celibacy and who listen to the scriptures of the Sage — they will be freed from saṃsāra and attain the supreme, most excellent, deathless state.

Practice the holy life of celibacy, offer gifts to those worthy of veneration, abide in the restoration ceremonies, and diligently cultivate loving-kindness. Be heedful, and continually perform acts of merit. Through these virtuous deeds, one brings suffering to its final end.

When the Blessed One had spoken these words, those monks rejoiced and praised what the Blessed One had taught.

The Sūtra of Maitreya is complete.

This was translated at the great monastic academy of glorious Tharpa Ling, the seat of those learned in both languages, under the guidance of the great paṇḍita Āranda Śrī, by the learned translator, the Śākya monk Nyima Gyaltsen Palzangpo.

Translator's Notes

- The five periods described here — up to fruits, accomplishment, scripture, signs, and relics — reflect a distinctive periodization of the decline of the Dharma after a buddha's passing, preserved in certain Maitreya-sūtra traditions. This schema differs from the more common three-period or five-period degradation schemas found elsewhere in the canon.

The colophon at the opening names the translator as Zangpo and identifies the place of translation as Palthaling, a great monastic college seat for bilingual scholars. The phrase rendered "like the sun and moon above the earth" is a conventional auspiciousness formula.

The Aṅga collections mentioned toward the end refer to the ancient limb-categories of early Buddhist scripture. The terms rendered "later Aṅga collection," "Saṃyukta collection,"

"middle-length collection," and "long collection" correspond roughly to the Khuddaka, Saṃyutta, Majjhima, and Dīgha Nikāyas or their Tibetan equivalents, though the exact canonical mapping is uncertain given the Tibetan text's own terminology here.

The term rendered "Yamaka" is left as such since it refers to a specific canonical Abhidharma text by that name.

- The phrase rendered "Jātakas without verse" translates a term literally meaning "Jātakas without leaves" or "without folio," which the context and commentarial tradition suggest refers to Jātaka narratives transmitted without accompanying verse summaries, sometimes identified as a specific subset of the Jātaka collection. This rendering follows the most plausible doctrinal interpretation given the passage's enumeration of textual categories in decline.

The "ten powers" is a standard epithet referring to the Tathāgata's ten powers of knowledge, here used as a title for the Buddha himself.

- The phrase rendered "intermediate kalpa of weapons before which there are three intermediate kalpas of famine, disease, and weapons" is somewhat circular in the Tibetan; the structure seems to say that before the weapons kalpa arrives, these three calamities occur — but the weapons kalpa is itself the third of the three. This is a known doctrinal point in Abhidharma literature where the "intermediate kalpas of devolution" are listed as famine, disease, and weapons in sequence, each caused by a dominant affliction (craving, delusion, and corruption or hatred respectively). The translation follows the doctrinal reading.

The verse at the end is incomplete as given in the source passage, ending mid-enumeration; the translation renders exactly what is present.

- The rice-measure passage contains a series of archaic Indian units — the "cart-load" equivalents, the "kuba," and the "bra chen" — that are difficult to render with precision. The translation preserves the numerical sequence and approximate sense without forcing false equivalences, as the exact system of measure is uncertain and may reflect local scribal variation rather than a standardized Sanskritic scheme.

The king called "Kuśa" (Tibetan: rTsa-can rgyal-po, literally "the Grass King") is a figure whose identification within this eschatological text is contextually clear; the name is rendered here in its most natural Sanskrit equivalent.

The three instruments mṛdaṅga, muraja, and ālambha are Sanskrit loanwords preserved in the Tibetan transliteration and are kept in their Sanskrit form as they are technical musical terms with no standard English equivalents.

- The phrase rendered "only as far as a bird can fly in one breath" opens the passage and continues the verse description of the ideal land from the preceding section. The Tibetan reads literally "it is just as far as a bird can fly," which in context describes the spacing or traversable distance of towns or terrain.

The passage names Śaṅkhaṇḍa as "king of the conch" and "chief chanter" — Tibetan dung gi rgyal po and tshang bzang mdun na 'don, respectively. These are taken as a proper name and an honorific title of the brahmin officiant.

"Fallen sages and wandering deer" renders drang strong ltung ba dang ri dags rgyu ba'i gnas, literally "a place of fallen sages and roaming wild animals." This may describe a forest hermitage or a forest dwelling associated with ascetics.

- The phrase rendered as "the place where the sages fell" is a standard Tibetan epithet for the Deer Park at Ṛṣipatana (Sarnath), meaning literally "the falling-place of the sages." This rendering preserves the literal sense while the location will be clear to those familiar with Buddhist geography.

The term *udāna* (Tibetan: *ched du brjod pa*) denotes a spontaneous utterance or inspired declaration, a recognized category of canonical scripture. The verse preceding it is treated accordingly as a spontaneous proclamation.

The passage describing the body measurements beginning with "eighty-eight cubits" follows a genre of Buddhological description of the future buddha Maitreya's extraordinary physical form. The measurements of the lotus petals and the body proportions are rendered literally in accordance with the text.

- The term rendered "first fruit of the Dharma" translates a phrase meaning the first attainment in the stream of Dharma realization — likely stream-entry (*srotāpatti*), though the text uses a more general formulation. The contrast with "those who had not yet attained it" suggests a division between those who entered the path and those who had not, both being born in higher rebirths through hearing the teaching.

The "five acts of immediate retribution" are the five *ānantarya-karmas*: killing one's mother, killing one's father, killing an arhat, wounding a buddha, and splitting the Saṅgha. The list in the text overlaps with but also supplements this standard enumeration, which is why some items appear separately.

The Nirgrantha sect refers to the Jains, followers of Nigaṇṭha Nātaputta (Mahāvīra), whose naked ascetic practitioners are the "Nirgrantha" referred to here.

- The name "Āranda Śrī" is a Tibetan phonetic rendering of a Sanskrit name; the exact Sanskrit original is uncertain — it may be "Ānanda Śrī" — but the rendering here follows the Tibetan letters as closely as possible. "Tharpa Ling" is kept as a proper place name (a monastic institution). The phrase "deathless state" renders the Tibetan term for *amṛta* or *nirvāṇa* in this context, describing the unsurpassed and immortal liberation beyond cyclic existence.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.